



HEADCOUNT: ICL's new domestic signings with Dev (seated centre)

BCCI's team" and "not the official team of India". It is a remark that may come back to haunt BCCI. Just like the ghost of a television deal gone sour has today—in the form of ICL.

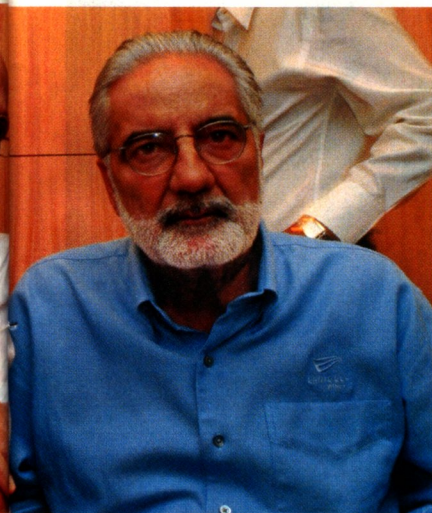
Chandra failed to win BCCI's lucrative television rights twice. Once in the regime of an old bete noire Jagmohan Dalmiya, and the second time when the Pawar faction—considered far warmer to Zee than Dalmiya—came to power. As a sop, Zee was awarded 'off-shore' rights to India matches which it walked away from. Before anything else, ICL is, allegedly, the result of Chandra's residual pique.

The cricket industry is watching this contest of egos and bank balances. Former India cricketer Saba Karim thinks the time for an alternative is ripe, "We're living in a liberalised country, why can't we have the same in sport?"

The advertisers seem bullish. Sundar Raman, managing director of media firm Mindshare which is the largest buyer of cricket spots on television, says, "ICL can help open up the market for a lot more advertisers... With reasonable opportunities for on-air and on-ground branding, I'd say it has the potential to expand the market." A sceptical television executive says, "You can't hire a bunch of junior artistes and expect to make a hit movie—without even having a cinema hall in which to show it."

BCCI partners like Thawani believe they have nothing to worry about, "Our contract with the Board protects us with regard to exclusivity of rights for domestic cricket in India... so the Board cannot participate in sanctifying a third-party league."

Where will this battle for territory end? Delhi lawyer Rahul Mehra, who filed a public interest litigation against BCCI, is pragmatic. ICL, he believes, will either merge with BCCI or BCCI will acquire it, like the New Zealand Cricket Board did with the 'Max Cricket' format. Mehra says, "ICL will first have to prove itself with performance, to show that it is a real alternative to BCCI." Wedded to power, flush with funds, BCCI and ICL are today scrapping for exactly the same prize. Not just cricket, but credibility. ■



ICL'S IMPACT

ICL has inadvertently asked key questions to and of BCCI

MONOPOLY

After telling the Supreme Court its main team is only a BCCI squad, why not an alternative Team India?

CONTROL

After the first news of ICL's plans, why did BCCI not issue contracts to its best domestic players?

FUNCTIONING

After 75 years in existence and a flood of funds today, why squander chance after chance to professionalise?

were planned much earlier but ended up looking like a knee-jerk reaction to the defections.

BCCI may not show it but they are paying attention. Their vocabulary is now remarkably free of retribution or stern action. The rebels, they say, have "exercised their choice" and "would not enjoy the benefits" given by BCCI. These include participation in official first-class cricket, future employment and financial payouts like pensions. But

should a rebel take BCCI to court in the future for withholding his pension or benevolent fund, the Board will have more on its hands than Dev on a hunger strike outside their swish new offices.

Inadvertently, ICL raises questions about BCCI's monopoly, control and functioning. During arguments in the Supreme Court in 2005, the Board's legal counsel K.K. Venugopal had declared that the team we thought of as the national squad was, in fact, "the